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Imagining a Canadian Identity through Sport: *A Historical Interpretation of Lacrosse and Hockey*

Sport in Canada during the late 19th century was intended to promote physical excellence, emotional restraint, fair play, and discipline; yet these ideological principles were consistently undermined by the manner in which Canadians played the game of hockey. This article explores the genesis of violence in hockey by focusing on its vernacular origins and discusses the relevance of violence as an expression of Canadian national identity in terms of First Nations and French Canadian expressions of sport.

IN *IMAGINED COMMUNITIES*, BENEDICT ANDERSON convincingly reduces the concept of nationalism to an imagining—imagined “because members of even the smallest nation will never know most of their fellow-members, meet them, or even hear of them, yet in the minds of each lives the image of their communion” (1991:6). It is this notion of communion that motivates nations to define and articulate their amorphous existence. If Anderson is correct—which I believe to be the case—the task of defining a national identity is a creative process that requires constructing a shared history and mythology(ies) that best suit the identity *imagined* by those few responsible for responding to this task. For a nation as young as Canada (confederated in 1867), this constructive process is somewhat recent and largely incomplete, which is disconcerting for Canadians who have twice witnessed the threat of national separation.¹ As a result, what it means to be Canadian is often scrutinized, lamented, and at times even celebrated (most recently through a Molson Canadian Beer advertisement).² Yet through all of this there has been one expression of nationalism that has remained constant since confederation, that being the game of ice hockey.³

Since World War II, Canadians have been internationally perceived more as peacekeepers and, perhaps, even as being unreasonably polite—both political constructions in themselves—which makes it difficult to comprehend why a game such as hockey, known for its ferocity, speed, and violence, would come to serve as Canada’s primary national symbol. The mystery intensifies if we consider that the game of hockey was born out of a period of social reform in Canada, where popular pastimes that involved violence, gambling, and rowdiness were being replaced by more “civilized”

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leisure pursuits imported from Europe. For instance, cricket, as Richard Gruneau states, was

especially palatable to Canada's colonial merchants and aristocrats because it combined an excellent and enjoyable forum for learning discipline, civility, and the principles of fair play with a body of traditions and rules offering a ritual dramatization of the traditional power of the colonial metropolis and the class interests associated with it. [1983:104]

The question becomes, then, how did a game such as hockey not only take shape in Canada, but become "frequently cited as evidence that a Canadian culture exists" (Laba 1992:333)? Furthermore, to what extent does the game of hockey embody a Canadian collective sensibility, or is this *imagining* of Canadian identity without justification even at a symbolic level? In order to respond to these questions, it is necessary to explore early vernacular forms of sport in this nation and consider how these sensibilities have maintained themselves in a contemporary sporting context.

The Process of Modernization

Sport historians and sociologists have documented extensively the development of physical activity from a traditional folk (vernacular) pastime to a modern organized event.⁴ Much of this discourse, however, concerns itself with the impact of modernization on traditional physical activities without taking into account the influences of traditional sporting behavior and its role in shaping (at least from a Canadian perspective) a national sport identity. Colin Howell is critical of these prejudicial tendencies and writes:

Modernization theory views history as a linear continuum in which any given circumstance or idea can be labeled "pre-modern" or traditional, and thus, can safely be ignored as something that the seemingly neutral process of "modernization" has rendered anachronistic. [1995:184]⁵

What needs to be understood is that the process of modernization is not, in fact, a linear progression, but rather a series of contested stages that maintain certain aspects of the past, while housing them in an entirely different framework. Before further discussing the relationship between traditional and modern sport, a brief explanation of these terms is necessary.

In sport theory, loosely organized, periodic, and self-governed sporting contests fit under the rubric of *traditional* sport (Metcalf 1987:11). This form of physical activity is devoid of field or participant specifications, and "was closely interwoven with established conventions of ritual . . . as well as the daily and seasonal rhythms of domestic and agrarian production, entertainment and religious festivals" (Gruneau 1988:12–13). There is a tendency to refer to traditional sport as rural, tribal, and in the past tense; in truth, however, this manner of participation continues to exist in a variety of forms. An example would be road/ball/pond hockey in which people engage in variations of the game of hockey in unspecified locales, with unspecified participants in terms of age, number, gender, and skill; these spontaneous games are performed around daily routines, whether these routines be dictated by work, school, personal, or familial

responsibilities. For this reason, I have substituted the term *traditional* with *vernacular*, as it connotes similar meanings but remains viable in a contemporary context and is, in fact, clearer.

The significance of the term *modern* sport is twofold in that it relates not only to the changes that have taken place in the way people engage in play, but *modern* also implies the political motivations that dictated these changes. To begin, modern sport is not a random pursuit but rather a highly organized event played within specific boundaries and performed with uniform rules maintained by leagues and organizations. In time, equipment becomes standardized and play becomes recorded and measured. The result is greater uniformity over time and space, reducing the “localized forms of individual and community-based expressions of pleasure, entertainment, physical prowess, and ritual display” (Gruneau 1988:13). Importantly, the consequence of this reductive process was not simply the limiting of specific expressions of sport but behavior itself has been reduced to satisfy a limited and highly specific social order. Pierre Bourdieu explains that “it would be a mistake to forget that the modern definition of sport is an integral part of a ‘moral ideal,’ that is, an ethos which is that of the dominant fractions of the dominant class” (1993:344), notions that were instilled and maintained by religious and education institutions (Wheeler 1978:192). It is through the standardization of sport that undesirable qualities of vernacular play could be eliminated—behaviors such as violence, public disorder, and mass rowdiness—thus controlling behavior to ensure a compliant and nonvolatile populace. However, it must be stressed that while levels of control were successfully manufactured through sport, and play was indeed standardized, “undesirable” vernacular elements were not, in fact, entirely reduced but actually remain critical features of specific sports such as lacrosse and hockey.

The political motivations behind the modernization of sport cannot be separated from the actual changes that occurred in expressions of physical activity. In Canada, these motivations stemmed from a British Victorian sensibility. By the turn of the 18th century, sport in Britain was being realized as an excellent means of social control and conditioning (Jarvie and Maguire 1994:109). The successes that church and school officials had enjoyed by providing the ever-increasing urban working class with productive nonthreatening activities, such as cricket and a (“refined” version of) football, were soon being implemented in the colonies as a means of “correcting” the rougher, more vulgar vernacular pastimes. Perhaps even more importantly, there was symbolic value in having newly colonized peoples engaging in these uniquely British activities; thus, regulated sport quickly became a vehicle for cultural imperialism. Metcalfe speaks to the imperialistic role of cricket by stating that it “illustrated the powerful forces of tradition and the way in which dominant social groups perpetuated their way of life in the face of massive social change” (1987:17).

In early-19th-century Canada, attempts were well underway to introduce imported European games such as cricket and curling to a nation only beginning to take shape. However, in its earliest stages organized sport was something suitable only for “gentlemen” and not worthy of the working class or ethnic minorities. Howell points out that while “middle-class reformers advocated a more disciplined and rational approach to leisure, seeking to replace irrational and often turbulent popular or working-class recreations with more genteel and improving leisure activities,” these “bourgeois sportsmen”

primarily “concentrated their attention on the improvement of middle-class youth” (1995:14). It was not until later in the century that schools and churches began to take a more active role in introducing structured forms of physical activity to Canadians of various class and ethnic backgrounds. The intent of making sport and physical activity more socially democratic was threefold: to acquire levels of control over increased amounts of leisure time made possible by industrialization and a shorter workweek; to reduce class conflict by enabling male participants of various backgrounds to compete on an equal playing field; and to build a physically fit yet subordinate workforce, ensuring maximum levels of industrial production. In short, advocating for institutionalized sport served as an important means of reproducing a Victorian social order in Canada, where young men learned to be honorable and genteel gentlemen. As with any hegemonic process,⁶ however, control was never absolute, and almost immediately emergent and residual cultures affected the desired outcome in unexpected ways.

Resisting an Imported Canadian Identity

The development of “controlled” sport took an important turn by the middle of the 19th century with a new emergent class—led by Montreal-born dentist, George Beers—responding to impositions of British nationalism in Canada. Beers’s role in Canadian sport history was that of a romantic nationalist, as his politics were comparable to Herder’s romantic nationalism of 18th-century Germany. Like Herder, Beers understood that to construct a national identity, two things needed to occur. First, foreign influence needed to be eliminated—Herder contended with French influence; Beers contended with English imperialism. And second, a national history/mythology needed to be consciously constructed. Instead of turning to indigenous poetry and language as Herder did, Beers turned to indigenous sport as a means of portraying the soul of a nation. What better place to look, he surmised, than Canada’s First Peoples whose game of *baggataway*—filled with speed, violence, and skill—appeared to best embody the harsh and grueling existence of Canadian natives as well as the trials of early Canadian settlers in this new and untamed land.

The game *baggataway*, renamed lacrosse by French settlers,⁷ was played by many First Nations (Native Canadians) across North America prior to European contact, and it proved to be a game that both fascinated and repulsed early settlers (Eisen 1994:2). Some English Europeans were least sympathetic to First Nations’ leisurely activities largely because of puritanical sensibilities that tended to perceive all forms of play as wasteful and unproductive. It is not surprising that English observations of lacrosse disparaged the violence; yet negative comments were often countered with admiration for First Nations players who exuded remarkable sportsmanship and respect for their opponents. One late-18th-century account reads:

The Chippewas play with so much vehemence that they frequently wound each other, and sometimes a bone is broken; but notwithstanding these accidents there never appears to be any spite or wanton exertions of strength to affect them, nor do any disputes ever happen between the parties. [Carver 1956:237]

More detailed accounts of lacrosse come from French missionaries and settlers, who, unlike the English, lived with First Nations peoples and made efforts to learn their language, customs, and social practices. One of the earliest accounts comes from Nicolas Perrot, who encountered the game while living as a *coureur de bois*⁸ between 1665 and 1684:

Il y a parmi eux un certain jeu de crosse qui a beaucoup de raport avec celui de nostre longue paume. Leur coustume en jouiant est de se mettre nation contre nation, et, s'il y en a une plus nombreuse que l'autre, ils en tirent des hommes pour rendre égale celle qui ne l'est pas. Vous les voyez tous armez d'une crosse, c'est à dire d'un baston qui a un gros bout au bas, lacé comme une raquette; la boule qui leur sert à jouer est de bois et à peu près de la figure d'un oeuf de dinde. [1973:43–44]⁹

[Among them there is a certain game of crosse that compares to our tennis. Their custom is to play nation (tribe) against nation (tribe), and if one side has more players than the other, more players are brought forth to ensure a fair game. Each has a stick, called a crosse that has a big curve at the end that is laced like a racket; the ball that they play with is made of wood and looks a little bit like a turkey's egg.]

He continues by describing the violent nature of the sport:

Vous entendez le bruit qu'ils font en se frappant les uns contre les autres, dans le temps qu'ils veulent parer les coups pour envoyer cette boule du costé favorable. Quand quelqu'un la garde entre les pieds sans la vouloir lascher, c'est à luy d'éviter les coups que ses adversaires luy portent sans discontinuer sur les pieds; et s'il arrive dans cette conjoncture qu'il soit blessé, c'est pour son compte. Il s'en est veü, qui ont eü les jambes cassées, d'autres les bras, et quelques uns ont esté mesme tüzé. Il est fort ordinaire d'en voir d'estropiez pour le reste de leurs jours, et qui ne l'ont esté qu'à ces sortes de jeu par un effect de leur opiniâtreté. [1973:45]

[One can hear the noise they make when they hit one another, while they attempt to avoid receiving blows in order to throw the ball to a favorable location. If one secures the ball in his feet without letting it go, he must fend off blows from his opponents who continually strike his feet; and if in this situation he is injured, it is his own concern. Some are seen with broken legs or arms, or are even killed as a result. It is common to see players maimed permanently, yet this does not change the way they play the game on account of their obstinacy.]

For many young French males, the rough nature of the sport was appealing, and as a result, these men became enamoured with not only the game of lacrosse but with its participants as well.

The radical impositions of European colonization on North American indigenous peoples has been taken to task in recent academic and popular discourse; clearly, arguments that perceive this relationship to be unidirectional are often overstated. In *The Skyscrapers Hide the Heavens*, Miller offers some balance to this historical analysis by revisiting early Euro–Indian relations and discussing them in terms of cultural change, both “non-directed” and “directed” (2000:95). In other words, Miller understands these relations as being far more equitable than is often portrayed. Not only did First Nations peoples often *willingly* take advantage of such things as European technology to benefit their own situations, but Miller documents, as well, the gross reliance of European

settlers on First Nations knowledge and technologies. In fact, he states that European survival in Canada would not have been possible without First Nations assistance and charity. Furthermore, and more importantly for our purposes, is the knowledge concerning the extensive cultural borrowings of European settlers (in this case French) from First Nations peoples.

For a certain sector of French Canadian males—later known as *les Canadiens*—the First Nations male provided an alternative model of masculinity to what they had known in France, one where physicality, stoicism, and bravado were valued and celebrated, not repressed, as was the typical Christian model of masculinity:

The young voyageurs struggled to copy the Indians' stoicism in the face of adversity and their endurance when confronted with hardship, deprivation, and pain. They also copied, to the extent that their employers and governors could not prevent, the autonomy that Indian society inculcated in its young. French males found the liberated sexual attitudes of young Indian women before matrimony as attractive as the missionaries found them repugnant. [Miller 2000:54]

Early French settlers began emulating First Nations males, and in doing so began sharing in their cultural practices. Occupational and survival-related pursuits such as canoeing, snowshoeing, and hunting were some of the obvious activities that were learned and performed. Native team sports such as lacrosse also proved to be of tremendous interest to *les Canadiens*, as these games gave both First Nations and French males the opportunity to prove their worth to one another as men. According to Joseph Oxendine, these white settlers did not fair very well, however, "because of the Indian's clear superiority of the game. Indians were frequently reported to have used fewer players in an effort to equalize the competition" (1988:48). First Nations proficiency at lacrosse was highly regarded by early sport enthusiasts, but these skills were also perceived by others to be violent and dangerous, a perception that began generating its own folklore among the early North American settlers.

Perhaps the most popularly known lacrosse event was a legendary contest between two First Nations tribes at Fort Michilimackinac in 1763—an ambush disguised as a sporting contest. According to Alexander Henry's account of the "contest," the tribes used lacrosse as a means of staging an attack on the British Fort during the Pontiac Rebellion (Henry 1901). Francis Parkman supports this in his account, which states:

Suddenly, from the midst of the multitude, the ball soared into the air and . . . fell near the pickets of the fort. This was no chance stroke. It was part of a preconcerted stratagem to insure the surprise and destruction of the garrison. . . . The shrill cries of the ball-players were changed to the ferocious war-whoop. The warriors snatched from the squaws the hatchets, which the latter . . . had concealed beneath their blankets. Some of the Indians assailed the spectators without, while others rushed into the fort, and all was carnage and confusion. [1962:254]

It was the legendary status the sport commanded that made it the perfect vehicle for George Beers's nationalist agenda. The game ran counter to British bourgeois sensibilities that understood sport to be refined and gentlemanly, one that could ultimately serve as a breeding ground for proper British mores and values. Instead, lacrosse was a display of rugged, brutal, and aggressive behaviors that were said to embody what it

meant to be a Canadian settler in this unforgiving northern territory. Thus, Beers called on Canadians to refrain from engaging in the imperial pursuit of cricket and take up lacrosse as the new national game, in effect ridding Canada of foreign influences and acquainting the new populations with the soul of the nation.

In order to make this fictitious proposal possible, the native game needed to be claimed by the male settlers and then incorporated into a modern sporting climate. Baggataway, as First Nations peoples played it, was not merely a sport but a spiritual and religious occasion, often having healing or prophetic significance.¹⁰ The game also had regional and tribal idiosyncrasies, which meant that there was no standard form of play, making Euro-Canadian adoption difficult. Thus, baggataway as a native vernacular entity needed to be transformed into lacrosse, which meant claiming the game and eliminating traits that were linked to First Nations culture. To achieve this transformation, it was necessary to standardize the rules to create a sense of uniformity. An important step was made, in fact, by George Beers, who published the first rules of lacrosse under the name “Goal-keeper” in a series of advertisements in the *Montreal Gazette* in 1860 (Cosentino 1998:15). These rules were later adopted by the Montreal Lacrosse Club and became the “official” rules of lacrosse, later republished in the *Montreal Gazette* in July of 1867 (Morrow 1989:47). Efforts to standardize the game not only eliminated regional variation, but also seemed to dictate how the game of lacrosse was to be played. All that was left, then, was to attract people to the game, and, again, in this Beers was instrumental.

Through various print forms (magazines and newspapers), Beers began to promote lacrosse as Canada’s national game, and in the process deride cricket as foreign and irrelevant to Canadians. In an article that appeared in the *Montreal Gazette* in August of 1867, suitably entitled, “The National Game,” Beers writes:

As cricket, wherever played by Britons, is a link of loyalty to bind them to their home so may lacrosse be to Canadians. We may yet find it will do as much for our young Dominion as the Olympic games did for Greece or cricket for our Motherland. [1867]

Of course, Beers makes no apologies for appropriating an aboriginal game and promoting it as the national pastime. Instead, he sees appropriation as an accurate depiction of European presence in Canada and argues, “just as we claim as Canadian the rivers and lakes and land once owned exclusively by Indians, so we now claim their field game as the national field game of our dominion” (1867). Beer’s proselytizing was enormously effective, to the extent that a National Lacrosse Association was formed—the first national sporting body in Canada—and lacrosse was being touted by many as Canada’s official national game.¹¹

These developments, which documented how a vernacular sporting pastime was transformed into a modern sport, were not as complete as scholars have suggested. Sports historian Don Morrow claims: “At first heralded in adoption, then transformed in nature, the Indian origins of the game were finally shunned by nineteenth-century white promoters and players” (1989:46). While ritual/sacred components and regional variations were erased from modern lacrosse competitions, there were native/vernacular elements of the game that remained, largely to the chagrin of elite sporting officials

who were governing these developments. To begin, the popularization of lacrosse did not arise merely because of Beers's ideological ravings. It is incorrect to claim, as Morrow does, that the new national affinity of lacrosse was achieved through the word of George Beers. Crediting only one person simply does not allow for human agency, and while public consciousness can be influenced, it is not something that can be dictated. In other words, there needed to be some preexisting value in lacrosse that allowed it to be so willingly adopted by Canadian sport enthusiasts. It is here, then, that we can begin examining the cultural value of lacrosse (and later hockey) and its relationship to Canadian identity.

Sport Sensibilities in Conflict

One of the primary reasons lacrosse served as a viable alternative to imported British sports such as cricket was its emphasis on physical aggression, volatility, and danger. The game appealed to males who identified with a more physically aggressive notion of masculinity rather than the reserved and civil expressions of masculinity exemplified in cricket. In essence, the attraction to lacrosse was an extension of early French Canadians' infatuation with First Nations masculinity, where the emphasis was on physical superiority, bodily awareness, and perseverance. Lacrosse provided males the opportunity to display these heralded qualities and challenge themselves through formal competitions. However, in the attempt to modernize lacrosse and market it to a broader audience, the game needed to become less violent and needed to be played in a manner more suitable for "gentlemen"; otherwise the game would not enter dominant sport culture. Efforts were in place to sanitize the game, but they were not entirely successful. In fact, those who were most successful at the sport were First Nations and working-class players who played the game as it was originally designed—aggressively and intensely. Attempts to turn the game into something else merely put those who engaged in it as "gentlemen" at a clear disadvantage to those who maintained its aggressive style of play. One team renowned for its aggressive play was the Montreal Shamrocks, who "were, without question, the most successful team prior to 1885. . . . The Shamrocks were out of place both socially and athletically. Social misfits on the middle-class playing fields, the Shamrocks were Irish, Roman Catholic, and working-class" (Metcalf 1987:196).

What is critical here is that the ideological and political value of lacrosse as advocated by those in power paled in relation to the actual meanings early participants experienced through playing it. Colin Howell, also a sports historian, correctly observes that lacrosse was "a relatively minor sport" that "was suddenly elevated to prominence because of the symbolic role that was associated with it at the time of Confederation" (Howell 1995:103). However, those elite officials who helped elevate the status of lacrosse understood the sport symbolically, not according to its literal value as a meaningful expression of Canadian consciousness. I do not wish to imply that this is a singular phenomenon, but there is evidence that lacrosse did have value for certain Canadian males as an identifiable articulation of who they were as men. In essence, lacrosse did signify class, gender, and ethnic values, but these values were generally unacknowledged by elite sporting officials who were suddenly threatened by their own ideological

maneuverings. The official recourse was to prohibit the “people” from playing the game and to attempt to make it instead the game of an exclusive minority:

The logical conclusion for lacrossists was that the incidence of disputes, violence, and undesirable conduct on the field of play could mean only one thing—some players were not gentlemen. The truth of this observation was given substance by the presence of Indians, who always played for money and, by race alone, could not be gentlemen, and of the working-class Shamrock team. [Metcalf 1987:195]

This prohibition of undesirable participants eventually led to the introduction of amateurism.

Amateur athletics in Canada did not merely function as a means of ensuring that athletes engage in sport in a gentlemanly manner,¹² but served as a discriminatory system that prevented “undesirable” players from playing. Prior to 1909, the year when a national amateur athletic union was formed in Canada, national sporting bodies used the concept of amateurism to best suit their sport’s needs. In the case of the National Lacrosse Association, league officials decided to make it an “amateur” association restricted to those players who fit under the definition of amateur. An amateur was conveniently defined by the Amateur Athletic Union of Canada as someone who had “never competed for a money prize, or staked bet with or against any professional for any prize,” or one who “never taught, pursued, or assisted in the practice of athletic exercises as a means of obtaining a livelihood” (Metcalf 1987:105–106). The stipulations were highly restrictive and deliberate in design.

First, the new requirements made working-class participation virtually impossible, in that wage earners were no longer able to receive financial compensation for taking time off from work to play. Keeping in mind that it was illegal to play sports on Sunday, and that the workweek ran from Monday to Saturday, working-class participation in sport was restricted generally to Saturday afternoons. As a result, players were not only prevented from receiving payment for time lost at work, but those players who at one time received compensation for their services were no longer eligible to play. The second aspect of the restrictions was equally effective because it denied access to individuals who at one time gambled on sport. During this period in Canadian history, gambling and sport were virtually inextricable: gambling made up part of the fabric of vernacular sporting pastimes. For First Nations cultures in particular, gambling in sport (by spectators and participants) was deeply ingrained in their traditions and at times even played a role in their overall economies (Oxendine 1988:31). Therefore, by these first two stipulations alone, most ethnic minorities and working class players were considered ineligible and could no longer play amateur athletics. The final stipulation reinforced economic divisiveness further by making it clear that sport was not the property of the people but, rather, of men who “had the leisure, economic resources and social approval to explore intensive athletic training in a financially disinterested manner” (Burstyn 1999:224).

The restrictive measures imposed by the National Lacrosse Association did not go unchallenged, however. Teams tried to circumvent the rules by covertly using “professional” players to become more competitive, and in certain cases even paid players for

their services. In response, the National Lacrosse Association was compelled to enforce disciplinary measures to contend with these dissident organizations. Teams caught cheating were brought before the Canadian Amateur Athletic Union to face arbitration and potential censuring.¹³ As these arbitration cases grew in number, tremendous pressures were being placed on the National Lacrosse Association to retract its strictly amateur policy and permit both professionals and amateurs into the league. Despite this, the National Lacrosse Association remained steadfast in its position to prohibit professional players and was ultimately successful in maintaining itself as an amateur association; this success, however, proved to be its inevitable downfall.

By maintaining its exclusive membership, the National Lacrosse Association forced potential lacrosse players to pursue alternative sporting options. Other team-sport leagues (i.e., baseball, football, and hockey) were not as resistive to the influences of professionalism, and thus, they provided working-class and ethnic minority players alternatives to play in these sports, and be financially compensated at the same time. While baseball and football did attract many of the players, these sports did not possess the symbolic and literal value found in lacrosse. Instead, it was hockey that early Canadian sport enthusiasts embraced by the turn of century, for the same reasons they were attracted to lacrosse 20 years earlier. Unlike baseball or football, hockey was seen as uniquely Canadian in origin and character. An amalgam of modern and vernacular sporting pastimes, hockey resembled lacrosse in design and in the manner it was played. Play was aggressive and often violent, providing men the opportunity to display this emergent notion of masculinity. At a symbolic level, it was played on a frozen landscape, perfectly embodying what life as a Canadian colonialist was supposed to be like. Thus, hockey provided all that lacrosse entailed, but without the restrictions of amateurism. By the 1920s hockey had succeeded in becoming Canada's national sport pastime.

Violence, Masculinity, and Canadian Identity

It is here, then, that we return to the politics of identity and the manner in which hockey, a game notoriously aggressive and violent, serves as a potential symbol for national expression. Along with other social scientists,¹⁴ I have been critical of popular discourse that tends to mythologize hockey and locate it as a unifying force in this nation. Gruneau and Whitson astutely observe:

The myth of hockey as a "natural" adaptation to ice, snow, and open space is a particularly graphic example of what Barthes is alerting us to—about how history can be confused with nature. . . . This discourse of nature creates a kind of cultural amnesia about the social *struggles* and vested interests—between men and women, social classes, regions, races, and ethnic groups—that have always been part of hockey's history. [1993:132]

While these sentiments are certainly valid, it would be incorrect to say that hockey is without cultural or historical relevance in Canada. In fact, it is my contention that hockey is more than a mythological construct; it is a legitimate expression of Canadian national history and identity. Hockey *does* speak to issues of gender, race, ethnicity, and

ODDS AND ENDS AT THE HOCKEY STRUGGLE



Figure 1. Odds and ends at the hockey struggle.

region in this nation, albeit not in an entirely positive manner. For this reason, hockey moves beyond symbol and becomes more of a metaphoric representation of Canadian identity.

First, hockey was born out of postconfederation Canada,¹⁵ in a period of political uncertainty and unrest. Canada was a disparate nation, divided in terms of language, region, and ethnicity—lacking in identity and national unity. Thus, while hockey was used ideologically to express national sentiment, its value as a vernacular entity was equal to, if not greater than, its symbolic value. From the outset, hockey's violent and aggressive style separated itself from other bourgeois (European) pastimes, including the increasingly popular game of baseball that was entering Canada from the United States. Early games often appalled certain sport writers and sport officials who saw the violence on the ice and in the stands as unfit for gentlemen. J. W. Fittell provides two accounts of the first recorded game of hockey, which took place in 1875. The first, from *The Daily British Whig* states that “Shins and heads were battered, benches smashed and the lady spectators fled in confusion” (Fittell 1987:36). The other report from *The Montreal Witness* claimed that:

Owing to some boys skating about during play an unfortunate disagreement arose: one little boy was struck across the head, and the man who did so was afterwards called to account, a regular fight taking place in which a bench was broken and other damages caused. [Fittell 1987:36]

These accounts of violence are undoubtedly extreme, yet what is significant is that even in its earliest stages hockey was a sport perceived as excessively aggressive and violent within a modern European context.

THEY CALL FOOTBALL BRUTAL SPORT!

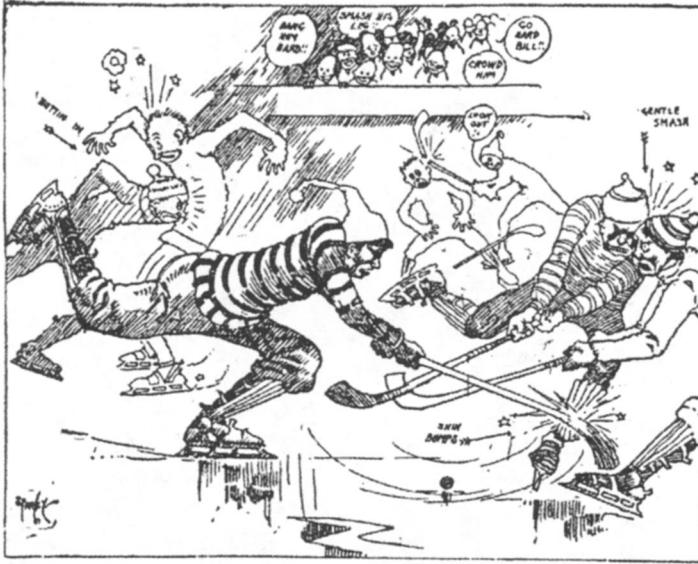


Figure 2. American cartoonists took to the slash and crash of Canadian players in Pittsburgh.

It was largely because of this excessive violence that hockey became a sport Canadians could call their own, and they quickly began to showcase it in international contexts. By the mid-1890s, competitions were being staged between Canadian hockey teams and American ice-polo teams. The Canadian teams dominated these early competitions and revelled in the press they received. Newspapers did applaud their skill, but at the same time reports were critical of their rough play. *The Daily Mining Gazette* of Houghton, Michigan, described one game as “rush, slash and check continually. . . . Calumet were knocked off the puck by Portage Lakes ‘any old way.’ Many a man had to be carried to the dressing room” (Fitsell 1987:120). In a game in Sault Ste. Marie, Michigan, an incident occurred where “Stuart [an American player] was laid out by a board check from Jack Laviolette. He recovered and tangled with the same player, fans rushed on the ice and as Stuart bled from the facial cuts, police were called in” (Fitsell 1987:120). These accounts illustrate that within 20 years of organized existence, hockey was internationally known as being first, Canadian, and second, notoriously violent. Further evidence of this is found in two American cartoons depicting Canadians playing hockey in Pittsburgh in 1904.¹⁶

The distinction hockey received as being a rough sport also served as a means for Canadians to display their proficiency in the clearly demarcated context of a sporting event, making hockey a valuable vehicle for expressing national identity. But it was not simply proficiency on the ice, it was physical proficiency within the masculinist tradition that was earlier identified in relation to lacrosse. Hockey displayed men who were perceived to be stoic, courageous, and physically dominant: precisely the same images of masculinity valued in First Nations culture, and later by early Canadian settlers. These historically pertinent attitudes attracted Canadians to hockey as the game provided Canadian males with an identifiable image outside of a British Victorian

framework. Moreover, through hockey competitions, Canadians could exude superiority over Americans, illustrating for many a “victory for the industrious Canadian beaver over the mighty U.S. eagle” (Fitsell 1987:106). In essence, hockey became a vehicle of resistance against British and American hegemony, something that Canadians continue to call on in periods of political or national uncertainty.

The political implications went beyond resistance to British and American rivalries. One such occasion was the 1972 Summit series in which Canadian professional hockey players engaged in an eight-game series against the Soviet Union national hockey team. The event was a debacle, yet it is considered by many to be the greatest Canadian story ever told. The series was described as East meets West—communism versus capitalism. So as the players rightfully admitted, it was no longer just about hockey. Reflecting on the series, team Canada member, Phil Espisito stated: “It wasn’t a game anymore; it was society against society . . . it wasn’t fun. It was *not* fun” (*September 1972* 1997). The series was filled with incidents of extreme violence: one Canadian player (Bob Clarke), following instructions from a coach, broke a Soviet player’s ankle with his stick. Other incidents involved a Soviet referee nearly being attacked by a Canadian player; throat-slitting gestures; kicking (with skates); fighting; and a *melee* with former NHL commissioner Alan Eagleson, the Soviet Guard, and the Canadian hockey team. The event, which was advertised as an expression of goodwill between nations, turned sour when the favored Canadians were defeated in the initial games and obviously outclassed in terms of skill and sportsmanship. Canadian players were simply unaware of the tremendous abilities of the Soviets and were hence, humiliated both on the ice by the Soviets, and off the ice by an unforgiving Canadian public who lambasted them with jeers.

In response to their dire predicament, Canadian players resorted to bullying and intimidation tactics and literally fought their way back into contention. In a miraculous comeback, overcoming real and imagined barriers, the Canadian team proved victorious, winning the final game and the series. Their “heroism” became permanently etched into the memory of Canadians, despite actions that have recently been described by two American journalists as “hacking and clubbing the Soviet players like seal pups and bullying their way to a thrilling, remarkable comeback” (Klein and Reif 1998:31). While there have been critics of the series, the games in the Canadian collective consciousness remain as “an orgy of self-congratulation about the triumph of ‘Canadian virtues’—individualism, flair, and most of all, character” (Gruneau and Whitson 1993:263). Historically speaking, these seemingly appalling behaviors are compatible with Canadian hockey in general, and for this reason are embraced, not denounced. The players performed in a manner consistent with Canadian play, illustrating a Canadian character that has yet to be defined in more concrete fashion. Therefore, despite Canadian behavior that was an assault on international hockey, and on international competition in general, this assault was distinctly Canadian, something which is invaluable for the construction of a national identity.

Conclusion

The connection I have made between hockey and Canadian nationalism is very real. I do not make the claim that Canadians are predisposed to violence or that they condone

violent behavior. Rather, I argue that hockey enabled Canadians to display qualities that have been valued in patriarchal relations: stoicism, courage, perseverance, and proficiency. The singularity of the game and the manner in which it was played were critical for a young and disparate nation to have as its own as it faced encroaching social, political, and cultural interests from Europe and the United States. At a more pedestrian level, hockey was accessible to men of various ethnic and class backgrounds, and thus, to a greater degree than lacrosse, it became a game of the people. The fact that “people” here is specific only to males established hockey as a male preserve, making it a popular site for males to define their worth as men, drawing on notions of masculinity that date back to 17th-century Canada. In this sense, understanding hockey beyond its mythological rhetoric acknowledges the “social *struggles* and vested interests—between men and women, social classes, regions, races, and ethnic groups” and confirms that hockey was, as Gruneau and Whitson state, “all of these” (1993:132).

Finally, by linking hockey to Canadian nationalism I am not situating either as being positive. In fact, the Canadian penchant to understand itself through hockey repeats masculinist formulas of identification that reflect poorly the lives of Canadians. The physically dominant, heterosexist, and capitalist associations of this specific identity are certainly exclusionary, but for that matter, all nationalist expressions cannot suitably speak for the polyphony of a nation. Despite the obvious fallibility of nationalistic representation, the legitimacy of nationalistic expression remains. Canada’s history is located firmly in patriarchy, heterosexism, and capitalism; thus, the use of hockey to promote national pride and unity was not random then, nor is it today. Playing hockey is a means of constructing an image of a nation in the manner in which dominant forces within it wish to be seen. With this, hockey does not merely symbolize the need to define a national identity, it offers insight into the actual imaginings of what this identity entails. Hockey provides Canada a means by which to be distinguished. As Benedict Anderson astutely observes, such distinction ought not to be characterized by the dichotomy of “falsity/genuineness, but by the style in which it is ‘imagined’ ” (1991:6).

Notes

1. The province of Quebec has twice voted to separate from Canada (1980 and 1995). The most recent referendum saw only 51 percent of Quebecers voting “no” to separation.

2. The television commercial gained national notoriety because of its pro-Canadian stance. It depicts an ordinary “Joe” pronouncing his Canadian identity in contrast to perceived stereotypes of Canadians. The following is “Joe’s Rant”:

Hey. I’m not a lumberjack or a fur trader. And I don’t live in an igloo, or eat blubber, or own a dogsled. And I don’t know Jimmy, Sally, or Suzy from Canada, although I’m certain they’re really, really nice. I have a Prime Minister, not a President.

I speak English and French, not American. And I pronounce it “about,” not “about.”

I can proudly sew my country’s flag on my backpack. I believe in peace-keeping, not policing; diversity, not assimilation. And that the beaver is a truly proud and noble animal. A toque is a hat, a chesterfield is a couch, and it is pronounced “zed” not “zee.”

Canada is the second largest landmass, the first nation of hockey, and the best part of North America! My name is Joe, and I *am* Canadian!

Thank you.

3. From this point forward ice hockey will be referred to as hockey.
4. See Gruneau 1983, 1988; Gruneau and Whitson 1993; Dunning 1975; Hargreaves 1986; Burstyn 1999; Metcalfe 1987; Morrow et al. 1989; Guttmann 1994; and Guay 1981.
5. Richard Gruneau in "Modernization and Hegemony" similarly recognizes the shortcomings of "overlooking, or misconstruing, the importance of social and cultural continuities in sport" (1988:19).
6. Guttmann expresses his dissatisfaction with the term *cultural imperialism* to describe sport diffusion. Instead, he prefers the term *cultural hegemony*, which better communicates the lively "contestation that has accompanied ludic diffusion" (1994:178).
7. It has been argued that the term *la crosse* was applied to the game because the sticks used by the participants resembled a bishop's crozier (Thwaites 1959:326). Maurice Jetté argues, however, that the name comes from "an old French game called 'la soule' which was played with a 'crosse' very similar to the Indian implement" that was also cross-like in shape (1975:14).
8. Literally means, "runner of the woods." More specifically, *coureurs des bois* were French male fur traders and trappers who lived as the indigenous population did during the 17th century. J. R. Miller writes that these young males were "neither French peasants nor Indian braves, they were a bit of both" (2000:56).
9. All translations provided by Robidoux unless otherwise stated.
10. Jean De Brebeuf, a Jesuit Priest, writes in 1636: "There is a poor sick man, fevered of body and almost dying, and a miserable Sorcerer [Shaman] will order for him, as a cooling remedy, a game of crosse. Or the sick man himself, sometimes, will have dreamed that he must die unless the whole country shall play crosse for his health" (Thwaites 1959:185).
11. Despite claims made in *The Story of Nineteenth-Century Canadian Sport* (1966) and the 1894 edition of the *Dictionnaire Canadien-Français* that Lacrosse was the national game of Canada, there are no official records that substantiate this claim (Morrow 1989:52–53).
12. Varda Burstyn writes, "For many of the founding sport associations of the late-nineteenth century, 'amateur' athletics meant 'gentlemen' athletics" (1999:49).
13. The Amateur Athletic Association of Canada changed its name in 1898 to the Canadian Amateur Athletic Union in an attempt to strengthen its position as a national sport governing body (Metcalfe 1987:110).
14. See Robidoux (2001); Gruneau and Whitson (1993); and Laba (1992).
15. Canada became a confederation in 1867, and the first recorded game of hockey took place in 1875.
16. The figures and caption are taken from J. W. Fittell's *Hockey's Captains, Colonels and Kings* (1987:119). The cartoons depict games that took place in Pittsburgh in 1904. No information is provided to indicate where they were originally published.

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